The Lights of Hollywood

By Janet O'Neill

ACTRESS: So you want to know why I'm here? I'm an actress. I came to Hollywood to see my name in lights. I came to act and that's what I do. For $40, I pretend to want a guy named Jack-knife. I pretend he doesn't remind me of my father. I act as if I want it. Badly. I close my eyes and pretend I'm dead. It's an advanced skill.

INTRODUCTION

From the earliest days of Hollywood, women have been stage managed and manipulated by older men in powerful positions. The idea that female actresses, hoping to "make it big" in Hollywood, are required to accept the attentions of older male studio executives and producers, is as old as the Hollywood hills. It's called "the casting couch" – and everyone has heard of it. But why? Why is there even a euphemism for this extreme form of sexual harassment? I'm young, I'm female, I want to see my name in lights . . . But this? This HAS to change.

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ACTRESS: My trip to Hollywood was destined. It was my fate. My senior year I played the role of Emily in Our Town and everyone said I was born for the stage. Are you thinking of acting for a career?, they'd say. Yes, I was. I was good. Even my drama teacher said so. When the next year rolled around and people started scurrying off to the various community colleges of the Tennessee area, I made a different trip. Hollywood. Truth be told, I wasn't in love with the acting. I never viewed it as some great art. I didn't even care about being adored on stage. It was the way they treat you when you're off stage that attracted me. The wine. The compliments. The parties. The lights.

My first audition. I was petrified. I never thought I would be, but as soon as

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the person before me started reading the same monologue from Our Ton, I realized I was merely a number. I had to be different. A star. I had to make them remember me. And you can bet I did that. I gave my monologue. Loudly. It was big. Then, for a reason I still can't rationalize, the words became jumbled. When I was supposed to say "Butternut tree", I said "Butternut bread". I'm sure it was a great promotion for the company. When I was supposed to say "Earth, you're too wonderful" I said "Ed, you're too wonderful". Damn my tenth-grade boyfriend! But my first audition was over. I didn't even look for call-backs. The answer was written in their laughter. They aren't laughing with you, they're laughing at you, I told myself.

Seasons changed quickly, yet California always appeared to look the same. One bad audition became two, became three, became ten. I lowered my sites. There's a ladder to climb in Hollywood. It starts with community theater, paid local theater, commercials, bit parts, TV, and then motion picture. As usual, I tried it backwards. I started with motion pictures . . . descended to community theater. They put me on stage crew. I was in charge of the lights. If only they knew.

My first break. While serving a sandwich to a man in a coffee shop, a man asked me to see him later. Said he was an agent. Oldest line in the book. I bought it. Turned out he really was. I got a job. An acting job. A real acting job. OK it was two lines in a commercial for Sunshine shoes, but it was a start. It wasn't my name in lights, but it was my face on TV. If I'd owned a TV, I would have seen it myself.

But, as fate would have it, the agent was too good to be true. Another of his clients got a job on One Life to Live out of New York and he went, too. Only

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about six nice people in Hollywood and a soap opera just took one of them. But he'd taught me well. I knew how to get a job now. I knew important people. Agents. Directors. One director I met was Kevin Stone. While serving a sandwich, I got him to notice me. "I'm the shoe girl!", I proclaimed too proudly. "Yes", he said, "You're very talented". Me? Talented? Sure. That's right. I forgot. He gave me his card and an appointment. Discovery was at my doorstep.

The next day, I came in for a preliminary interview. I read for a role. A lead role in a small, but artistic movie. The lead! We read scene after scene and I didn't stumble once. No butternut bread. No ex-boyfriend named Ed. Just me - putting my name in lights. I was so excited and then he said: OK, let's see your body. What? The role requires several nude scenes. Let's see your body.

Slowly, I took off all but my bra and underwear. Let's try this on more time. I need to see your body. I wanted the part so that's what I did. I wanted my name in lights, so that's what I did. I showed him my body. The next thing 1 knew he was on top of me. I wanted to tell him to be gentle, but my throat was dry. l kept thinking of my name in lights, but it wasn't enough. I kept thinking that I needed to please him, but I couldn't. He just kept on, acting as if I wasn't even there. Like this was his right. Like this was supposed to happen. Like it always happened. And I know this sounded crazy, but I screamed for my mom. I screamed for home. I screamed for anywhere but here. Not this. Not like this. It was my first time.

I was not raped that day, but I was violated.

And that's how I got here. No part. No movie. I'm not sure one even existed. But I learned a skill. Lie back; close your eyes; pretend you're dead. That's

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what I do. I develop my skills to take care of myself. But now I'm late. I mean I'm late. Now taking care of myself may not be enough. What am I gonna do? I find another man. I lie back. I close my eyes. Only this time I envision the lights. My name in lights. I see the brightness and then it fades to black.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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